

FIELD RESOURCE

12 Questions to Ask Your Real Estate Agent

A printable interview sheet for vendors comparing agents

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Most vendors interview two or three agents and choose the one with the highest quote. The agent who quotes high to win the listing then conditions the vendor down later, after the campaign starts and the buyer feedback comes in. The vendors who avoid this trap are the ones who interview agents the way you would interview a candidate for a senior job: with prepared questions, honest follow-ups, and a written record. This sheet gives you the twelve questions that matter most.

How to use this sheet

Print one copy for each agent you meet. Take notes during the meeting, not after. Compare the answers side by side once you have met all of them.

- ☐ Meet at the property in person. Phone or video calls are not enough.
- ☐ Allow 60 to 90 minutes per meeting. Anyone who rushes is signalling how they will run your campaign.
- ☐ Take notes during the meeting, including specific examples the agent gives.
- ☐ Ask the same questions of every agent. Comparison only works with consistency.
- ☐ Trust your read of the person, not just the answers. You will work closely with this agent for two to four months.

Track record questions

These three questions test whether the agent is genuinely the right fit for your suburb and price bracket.

- ☐ 1. How many properties have you personally sold in this suburb in the past 12 months? (Not the office. The agent personally.)
- ☐ 2. What was your most recent comparable sale to my property? Walk me through how you priced it, marketed it, and what it eventually sold for.
- ☐ 3. What is your average days-on-market in this suburb compared to the suburb average?

Strategy questions

These three test whether the agent has thought about your specific property or is using a template pitch.

- ☐ 4. What sale method (auction, private treaty, expressions of interest) would you recommend for this property and why?
- ☐ 5. What is your honest price range for this property, and what would need to happen for it to sell at the top of that range?
- ☐ 6. Walk me through the four-week campaign you are proposing. What happens in week one, week two, week three, and week four?

Communication questions

These three test whether the agent will be present through your campaign or will hand you off to a junior.

- ☐ 7. Who will personally run my campaign? Will it be you, or will you hand it to a junior?
- ☐ 8. What is the format and frequency of your communication with vendors during a campaign? Will I get a written report after every open?
- ☐ 9. How quickly do you typically respond to messages from vendors? What hours are you contactable?

Money questions

These three are the questions vendors most often forget to ask in detail. They are also the ones with the biggest financial impact.

- ☐ 10. What is your commission, and is it fixed or tiered? Walk me through what I would pay at three different sale prices.
- ☐ 11. What is the recommended marketing budget? What does it include, when is it paid, and what is non-negotiable versus optional?
- ☐ 12. If the property does not sell within the agency term, what happens? What are my options to extend, change agents, or withdraw?

Red flag answers to watch for

Some answers are warning signs. Pay attention to how the agent handles uncomfortable questions as much as to what they say.

- ☐ A price quote that is significantly higher than other agents you have met. The agent may be buying the listing.
- ☐ Reluctance to put the price quote in writing.
- ☐ Vague answers on commission structure or marketing budget.
- ☐ Generic strategy responses ("we will market it widely and run opens"). Strategy should be specific to your property.
- ☐ Personal track record that is much weaker than the office track record. The office sells homes, but the agent sells yours.
- ☐ No clear plan for what happens if the property does not sell in week three or four.
- ☐ Defensive responses to honest questions. You are interviewing a service provider, not asking for a favour.

Reading between the lines

A few quieter signals worth noticing.

- ☐ How the agent talks about other agents. Disparaging competitors usually means the agent is competing on volume rather than substance.
- ☐ How the agent talks about your property. Honest assessment of issues is a much better sign than blanket praise.
- ☐ How the agent talks about buyers. Empathy with both sides of a transaction is a sign of a sustainable career.
- ☐ Whether the agent asks you questions back. The best agents want to understand your timing, your priorities, and your alternatives before pitching.
- ☐ The quality of the written follow-up after the meeting. The follow-up is a preview of the campaign.

After the meetings, how to compare

The decision is rarely about price quote alone. A short structured comparison after the meetings helps avoid recency bias.

- ☐ Score each agent on track record, strategy, communication, and money on a simple 1 to 5 scale.
- ☐ List two strengths and one concern for each agent.
- ☐ Sleep on the decision for at least 24 hours.
- ☐ Call one or two recent vendors of each shortlisted agent. The agent should be willing to provide references.
- ☐ Choose the agent you would be comfortable with if the campaign got difficult, not the one with the highest opening number.

A good agent does not mind being interviewed. The agents most worth working with expect these questions and have clear answers. The agents you should avoid are the ones who get defensive when asked.

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